

Aletheia Case Draft — TIK-001

The Religion with No Name?

Did a psychedelic sacrament power the Eleusinian Mysteries — and did it pass into the original Christian Eucharist?

Case ID: TIK-001 · **Domains:** Classical archaeology · Archaeochemistry · History of religions · Early Christianity · Psychopharmacology **Subject:** Brian C. Muraresku, *The Immortality Key: The Secret History of the Religion with No Name* (St. Martin's Press, 2020, 460 pp.) ¹ **Status:** AI draft · unratified · prepared as a first-pass case file for Aletheia ingestion **Last update:** 2026-08-25 **Overall assessment:** **Mixed, by rung** — one word would mislead. The claim ladder fails at different rungs for its two halves:

- *Eleusis ladder:* **Weakly supported** (one genuine archaeological datum + demonstrated chemical feasibility; zero evidence from Eleusis itself)
- *Christianity ladder:* **Unsupported** → **contradicted** (no direct evidence of any kind; mainstream derivations run through Second-Temple Jewish meal liturgy; repudiated by the author's own scientific witnesses) **Research priority: High** — the decisive test (organic residue analysis of curated Eleusinian vessels) is cheap, well-defined, and blocked by permission, not science.

1. What is claimed

Muraresku spent twelve years (c. 2008–2020), as a practicing lawyer trained in Greek, Latin, and Sanskrit (Brown, Phi Beta Kappa; Georgetown Law), investigating “the religion with no name.” [2] The book self-describes as presenting “**the pagan continuity hypothesis with a psychedelic twist,**” and addresses two fundamental questions, verbatim:

“Before the rise of Christianity, did the Ancient Greeks consume a secret psychedelic sacrament during their most famous and well-attended religious rituals? Did the Ancient Greeks pass a version of their sacrament along to the earliest, Greek-speaking Christians, for whom the original Holy Communion or Eucharist was, in fact, a psychedelic Eucharist?” [3]

The publisher's framing is stronger: the book “reconstructs the suppressed history of women consecrating a forbidden, drugged Eucharist that was later banned by the Church Fathers.” [4] Muraresku's own framing to Charles Stang at Harvard was weaker: “wonderfully attractive and maybe even sexy circumstantial evidence for the potential use of a psychedelic sacrament amongst the earliest Christians” — and he concedes he never found “the smoking gun.” [5] **Note for the pipeline: the claim exists in at least three strengths (publisher > publicity > author's scholarly concession). Aletheia should assess the strong form and record the concession as evidence.**

The book was a *New York Times* bestseller (audiobook #10, November 2020), Audible “Best of 2020” (History), carries a foreword by Graham Hancock, a “groundbreaking” blurb from Michael Pollan, was optioned for television, and reached mass audiences via two Joe Rogan appearances (#1543 with Hancock; #2047 announcing the Athanatos Foundation). [2][6][7]

2. Claim ladder (atomic decomposition)

Credibility is assessed per rung — evidence for a lower rung does not automatically climb. Suggested claim IDs for Aletheia:

ID	Claim (strongest defensible form)	Assessment	One-line basis
TIK-C001	Psychoactive plants/fungi were used ritually across the ancient Mediterranean and Near East	Well supported	Direct chemical evidence: Tel Arad cannabis (8th c. BCE Judahite shrine) [8]; Menorca hair atropine/scopolamine/ephedrine (~1000 BCE) [9]; Bes vase <i>Peganum harmala</i> /blue lotus (2nd c. BCE Egypt) [10]; Tel Yehud opium (14th c. BCE) [11]
TIK-C002	Ancient wines/potions were routinely compounded with psychoactive botanicals	Well supported	Attested pharmacopeia (Homer' s <i>nepenthe</i> , Dioscorides); ORA of spiked/infused vessels (Cébazat tomb wine+THC biomarkers; Kabri wine cellar “psychoactivity”) [12][13]
TIK-C003	The Eleusinian <i>kykeon</i> contained ergot (<i>Claviceps purpurea</i>) and was psychedelic	Weakly supported	Ergot in a Demeter/Kore sanctuary vessel + human dental calculus at Mas Castellar de Pontós (Iberia, 4th–2nd c. BCE) [14]; chemical feasibility demonstrated 2026 [15]; but no ergot from Eleusis itself, no ancient text naming it, Hymn recipe is non-psychoactive [16]
TIK-C004	Ancient technology (wood-ash lye) could convert toxic ergot into a psychoactive lysergamide preparation	Well supported (as feasibility)	Antonopoulos et al. 2026: pH 12.5 lye, 120 min reflux → complete ergopeptide hydrolysis; 0.54 mg LSA + 0.48 mg iso-LSA per g ergot [15]. Feasibility historical use; authors say so [15]

Table 1 – continued

ID	Claim (strongest defensible form)	Assessment	One-line basis
TIK-C005	The transformative experience at Eleusis <i>required</i> pharmacology (fasting/ritual/drama insufficient)	Unresolved	Burkert/Henrichs/Cosmopoulos: non-drug mechanisms suffice (“communal bliss”) [17] [18]; no test adjudicates
TIK-C006	A psychedelic sacrament was transmitted from Greek mystery cults to the earliest Greek-speaking Christians	Unsupported	No residue, no text, no art from any Christian context; no transmission vector documented; author’ s own concession [5][19]
TIK-C007	The original Eucharist was a psychedelic potion	Contradicted (as history)	Earliest sources (1 Cor 11, Didache) describe bread and wine only; Jewish meal-liturgy matrix (kiddush/chaburah/berakah) is the documented antecedent [20]; McGovern: “extremely weak to nonexistent” [6]
TIK-C008	Pagan-continuity framework: Christianity descends from mystery cults (the model TIK inherits)	Contradicted (as framework)	<i>Religionsgeschichtliche</i> framework dismantled by J.Z. Smith/Mettinger; Ehrman: “no unambiguous evidence that any pagans prior to Christianity believed in dying and rising gods” [21]
TIK-C009	Women were the historical custodians/mixers of the potion, later suppressed by Church Fathers	Unsupported	Constructed from heresiology (Irenaeus on Marcus) and medieval witch-trial records; no early-Christian documentary support [22]
TIK-C010	Modern psychedelic science (Pahnke 1962; Griffiths 2006) shows the experiences TIK posits are pharmacologically real	Well supported (as data); irrelevant (as history)	Robust modern data [23] [24]; it is analogy, not evidence about antiquity —Psychedelic Medicine (2025) explicitly warns against this legitimization move [25]

Load-bearing claims: TIK-C003 (for the Greek half), TIK-C006 (for the whole thesis). **Weakest link:** TIK-C006 — the transmission vector. If C006 fails, C007–C009 fall regardless of what is found at Eleusis.

3. Where the disagreement lives

Not over whether ancient people used drugs (TIK-C001/C002 are now chemically secure), nor over whether the Mysteries were transformative (Sophocles, Pindar, Cicero attest they were). The crux is four narrow cells:

1. **The empty Eleusis cell.** No artifact, vessel, or residue from the Eleusis sanctuary has ever been chemically analyzed — the 2026 authors themselves state “no systematic research has ever been conducted or since permission for such has never been granted.” [15] Proponents read this as “not yet tested”; skeptics (Clinton) add that the sanctuary’s published, audited financial accounts name no drug expenditure. [6] Both describe the same empty cell.
 2. **The recipe problem.** The only ancient recipe (Homeric Hymn to Demeter, ~208–211: barley, water, pennyroyal/*glechon*) names nothing psychoactive, and ergot is named in no ancient source. [16] The hypothesis requires the active ingredient to be a secret additive — an unfalsifiable-by-text construction that cuts both ways.
 3. **The 1,000-km transfer.** The one hard datum — ergot in a ritual chalice and in dental calculus of a 25-year-old man at Mas Castellar de Pontós, a Demeter/Kore sanctuary near the Greek colony of Emporion — is in Iberia, four centuries before Christianity, at a different site and society. [14] It proves ergot in *a* Demetrian ritual context, not *the* kykeon at Eleusis.
 4. **The transmission vector.** Even granting C003, nothing documents a chain from Eleusis to 1st-century Christian table fellowship. The chronology is not itself fatal (the Mysteries ran until Theodosius I, 392 CE; emperors were initiated [26]) — but the earliest Eucharist sources are Jewish in form and content, and the only “drugged cup” text in the Christian record (Irenaeus, *Against Heresies* 1.13.2, on Marcus) is hostile polemic describing a conjuring trick. [22][20]
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4. Evidence ledger

4.1 PRO — evidence supporting rungs of the ladder

TIK-E001 ·The 1978 founding hypothesis. Wasson (ethnomycologist), Hofmann (discoverer of LSD, Sandoz), Ruck (Boston University classicist), *The Road to Eleusis: Unveiling the Secret of the Mysteries* (Harcourt Brace Jovanovich, 1978): barley of the Rarian plain hosted *C. purpurea*; water infusion could extract psychoactive ergonovine-group alkaloids and LSA while excluding non-water-soluble toxic ergopeptines. [27] Hofmann’s self-experiment (1 April 1976: 2 mg ergonovine maleate, ~6× the obstetric dose, “mild psychedelic activity... more than five hours”) was its pharmacological proof-of-concept. [28] *Strengths:* genuine interdisciplinary authority; a chemically real target. *Weaknesses:* no archaeological data; Hofmann himself conceded “we have no way to tell what the chemistry was of the ergot of barley or wheat raised on the Rarian plain in the 2nd millennium B.C.” [15]

TIK-E002 ·Mas Castellar de Pontós (the one real archaeological datum). Juan-Tresserras (2002): fragments of ergot inside a ceremonial vase and within the dental calculus of a 25-year-old man, in a sanctuary dedicated to the two Eleusinian goddesses near Emporion, 4th–2nd c. BCE. [14] Cited as supporting evidence by the 2026 *Scientific Reports* paper. [15] *Strengths:* real, peer-contextualized,

directly ergot-in-cult-context. *Weaknesses:* not Eleusis; not the kykeon; primary publication is a Spanish-language conference report — the primary text should be obtained and re-verified (see TIK-R006).

TIK-E003 ·The 2026 lye-hydrolysis experiment. Antonopoulos, Dadiotis, ..., Ruck, ..., Magiatis, “Investigating the psychedelic hypothesis of kykeon,” *Scientific Reports* 16:8757 (13 Feb 2026): pulverized *C. purpurea* sclerotia refluxed in wood-ash lye (initial pH 12.5; 5% w/v; 120 min; 100 °C) eliminated all six predominant toxic ergopeptides and their C-8 epimers, yielding 0.54 mg LSA + 0.48 mg iso-LSA per gram of ergot; ~1 g of ergot per initiate extrapolated; authors frame the result as feasibility and call for ORA of Eleusis material. [15] This retires the strongest pharmacological objection (ergot = ergotism = fatal) **at the level of possibility**. *Weaknesses:* COI structure (three co-authors from the Hellenic Center for Entheogenic Research/EPOPTeia, whose mission is validating Greek entheogen use, plus Ruck and Mark A. Hoffman of the Wasson Ruck Entheogenic Research Institute — the hypothesis’s originators co-authored its validation); no in vivo safety/psychoactivity data; LSA is a weak, sedating psychedelic with vasoconstrictive side-effects; the pennyroyal “entourage” claim is explicitly unvalidated. [29][30]

TIK-E004 ·The archaeochemistry wave (2020–2025) — the Athanatos highlights, verified.

- Pinwheel Cave, California (PNAS, Nov 2020): first unambiguous chemical confirmation of hallucinogen ingestion at a rock-art site — chewed *Datura wrightii* quids (atropine, scopolamine by LC-MS) in ceiling crevices; rebutted the Lewis-Williams entoptic model. [31]
- Es Càrritx, Menorca (*Scientific Reports*, Apr 2023): first direct chemical evidence of psychoactive consumption in ancient Europe — human hair with atropine (8.9 pg/mg), scopolamine (437 pg/mg), ephedrine (330 pg/mg), ~1000 BCE. [9][32]
- Bes vase, Ptolemaic Egypt (*Scientific Reports*, Nov 2024): *Peganum harmala* (harmine/harmaline — MAOI -carbolines), blue lotus, Cleome, fermented liquid, honey, and deliberately added human bodily fluids in a 2nd-c. BCE ritual mug. [10] *Caveat:* the vessel is **unprovenanced** (Cairo art market, 1960); single-vessel study; royal-jelly ID only ~73% spectral match. [10]
- Wider context: Tel Arad cannabis+frankincense altars (8th c. BCE Judahite shrine) [8]; Tel Yehud opium juglets (14th c. BCE) [11]; Pamir cannabis braziers (~500 BCE) [33]; Chavín vilca/Nicotiana inhalers (2025) [34]; Qurayyah *Peganum* fumigation (2025) [35]; Bolivia ritual bundle with harmine+DMT+bufotenine (2019) [36].
- **Critical framing:** none of these touches Eleusis or Christianity. They prove a *pattern* (ancient peoples everywhere used psychoactives ritually) that TIK invites readers to extend by analogy. The extension is the disputed move, not the data.

TIK-E005 ·Webster/Perrine/Ruck, “Mixing the Kykeon” (2000; 2008 appendix). The alkaline-hydrolysis “Ergine Hypothesis” — the direct intellectual precursor the 2026 paper experimentally executed 26 years later, with Ruck again co-authoring. [37]

TIK-E006 ·Institutional momentum. Yale Ancient Pharmacology Program (Andrew Koh, Peabody Museum, founded 2022 — Athanatos’ first grantee) applying GC-MS ORA to Greco-Roman ritual vessels; documented flagship result: opiate biomarkers in a Xerxes I alabastron (Yale Babylonian Collection; *JEMAHS* 13.3, 2025). [38][39][40] *Caveat:* Koh’s public stance is explicitly incrementalist (“let’s start with not so much of a light-year jump”); the stronger early-Christian goal language (“early Christian ritual and its pharmacological roots”) appears on the **funder’s** website, not Yale’s. [41][42]

TIK-E007 ·Comparative psychedelic science. Pahnke’s Good Friday Experiment (1962): 8/10 psilocybin vs 1/10 control mystical experiences among divinity students [23]; Griffiths et al. 2006: 33%

rated psilocybin session the single most spiritually significant experience of their lives; 61% complete mystical experience [24]. Establishes that the *kind* of experience the Mysteries promised (“dying before dying”) is pharmacologically inducible. Analogy, not history.

TIK-E008 ·Textual/philological threads (weak individually, inventory for completeness). “No Greek word for alcohol” → wine-as-potion argument [43]; 1 Cor 11:30 *koimōntai* read as “have died” [43]; Marcosian cup (Irenaeus AH 1.13.2) — actually hostile polemic about fraud [22]; Dionysian readings of John’s Gospel; catacomb *refrigeria* banquet frescoes — which mainstream art history reads as ordinary agape meals, no psychoactive flora identified. [19][5]

4.2 CON — evidence against, by rung

TIK-E101 ·The sanctuary accounts (Clinton). Kevin Clinton (Cornell), the leading Eleusis epigrapher: the Athenian sanctuary’s annually audited, stone-published financial accounts record grain flows for sacrifices and dedications — “none of it for the production of ergot or drugs”; TIK “demonstrates how *not* to do research on ancient religion.” [6]

TIK-E102 ·Burkert’s sufficiency argument. Walter Burkert, *Ancient Mystery Cults* (Harvard UP, 1987): fasting followed by the sacrificial meal suffices for “communal bliss”; the simplicity of the non-drug mechanism is what made the rite scalable to a mass religion over two millennia. [17] This remains the mainstream default in classics. [18]

TIK-E103 ·McGovern’s defection. Patrick McGovern (Penn Museum biomolecular archaeology; the book’s star scientific witness, cited ~70 times): any scientific evidence linking psychedelics to Christianity is “**extremely weak to nonexistent**”; Muraresku “misconstrues and overinterprets the very limited, ambiguous archaeological and archaeobotanical data... to reinvigorate the discredited ergot theory for Eleusis and to build a fanciful tale about the Eucharist with no basis in Christian tradition.” [6]

TIK-E104 ·Mystery-cult historians. Jan Bremmer (Groningen): “No cult is known that used mushrooms in antiquity, and Christianity was not a mystery cult.” Bart Ehrman: “I admire Brian’s tenacity... but I don’t think his findings at all plausible.” [6]

TIK-E105 ·The framework objection. The dying-and-rising-god / mystery-cult-continuity model TIK inherits was dismantled by Jonathan Z. Smith (category is a modern scholarly construction) and is rejected by mainstream Christian-origins scholarship; Ehrman: “no unambiguous evidence that any pagans prior to Christianity believed in dying and rising gods”; mystery cults are never mentioned by Paul or any 1st-century Christian author. [21]

TIK-E106 ·The Jewish matrix. The earliest Eucharist sources (1 Cor 11:23–25, c. 53–55 CE; Didache 9–10) and the rite’s documented antecedents (Passover, kiddush, chaburah, berakah) are Jewish table liturgies; patristic witnesses (Justin Martyr, *First Apology* 66, c. 155 CE) frame the rite christologically and treat pagan parallels as demonic imitation. [20][44]

TIK-E107 ·Religious-studies critique of the genre. Mosurinjohn & Ascough, “Psychedelics, Eleusis, and the Invention of Religious Experience,” *Psychedelic Medicine* (2025; DOI 10.1177/28314425251361835): TIK-type writing shows “a pattern of presenting claims, followed by mild circumstantial evidence, rhetorically solidifying the interpretation of this evidence into a ‘fact,’ on which is built each subsequent round of conjecture” — “evidentiary mirages”; psychedelic medicine should not derive legitimacy from this history. [25]

TIK-E108 ·Intra-movement critiques. Jerry B. Brown (himself an entheogen-history author), *Journal of Psychedelic Studies* 5(1) 2021: TIK “fails to make a compelling case for its grand theory... due

to recurring overreach and historical distortion... presentation of speculation as fact”; ignores the Old-Testament entheogen literature (Shanon, Merkur, Nemu). [3] Chris Bennett: the Catalonia material “would have been of better impact in a book focussed on Eleusis”; the toad-wine chapter misreads its source. [45] These matter more than hostile reviews — they come from the thesis’s own constituency.

TIK-E109 ·Art-history critique. Huggins (MDPI *Religions*, 2025): the “mushrooms in Christian art” corpus (Plaincourault etc.) fails evidentiary scrutiny — stylized-tree conventions, pigment analysis; Wasson himself warned to “beware of seeing mushrooms everywhere.” [46]

TIK-E110 ·The paideia review. David Hewett (Paideia Institute): a “regressive work” with “a predatory approach to the topic of Western religion... a P.R. campaign for its author and contemporary psychedelic therapy.” [6]

TIK-E111 ·The field’s own cautionary tale. The 1990s Balabanova cocaine/THC-in-mummies episode — now attributed to contamination and absent controls — is the standing reminder that archaeochemistry’s findings are only as good as its blanks. Modern flagship studies (Pinwheel, Menorca, Bes) use far stronger controls, but single-vessel unprovenanced results (Bes) inherit this history. [47]

TIK-E112 ·The author’s concession. “Sexy circumstantial evidence”; no smoking gun. [5] Concessions by the proponent belong in the ledger as evidence against the strong form of the claim.

5. Source register (annotated, pro and con)

Core PRO lineage: Wasson/Hofmann/Ruck, *The Road to Eleusis* (1978) [27] ·Webster/Perrine/Ruck, “Mixing the Kykeon” (2000) [37] ·Juan-Tresserras, Mas Castellar (2002) [14] ·Antonopoulos et al., *Sci Rep* (2026) [15] ·Robinson et al., *PNAS* (2020) [31] ·Guerra-Doce et al., *Sci Rep* (2023) [9] ·Tanasi et al., *Sci Rep* (2024) [10] ·Arie et al., Tel Arad (2020) [8] ·Linares et al., Tel Yehud (2022) [11] ·Brown’s JPS review (2021 — favorable on Eleusis half, harsh on the grand theory) [3] ·Koh/YAPP body of ORA work [38][39][40].

Core CON: Burkert (1987) [17] ·Clinton via Reason (2025) [6] ·Bremmer, Ehrman via Reason (2025) [6] ·McGovern via Reason (2025) [6] ·Nadeau, *Academia Letters* 4213 (2021) [48] ·Mosurinjohn & Ascough, *Psychedelic Medicine* (2025) [25] ·Bennett (2021) [45] ·Huggins, *Religions* (2025) [46] ·Hewett/Paideia [6] ·Stang/CSWR exchange (2021) [5] ·mainstream Eucharist-origins scholarship (Jeremias, Bradshaw, Mazza synthesis) [20].

Neutral/contextual: Homeric Hymn to Demeter [16] ·Wikipedia “Kykeon”/“Eleusinian Mysteries” (useful navigators, not authorities) [18] ·Visionary.art Pharmakon dossier (2026) — unusually well-structured independent analysis with an explicit evidence ladder [30] ·crazyalchemist balanced summary (2026) [49] ·ProPublica/CauseIQ filings for Athanatos [50][51] ·Luke & Koh 2025 funding disclosure [52].

6. Witness map (the debate’s meta-signal)

Nearly every credentialed figure the book relies on has publicly qualified or defected — specifically on the Christian claim. No comparable movement exists in the opposite direction. This asymmetry is itself decision-relevant.

Witness	Role in TIK	Current public stance
Patrick McGovern (Penn, d. 2025)	Scientific consultant; ~70 mentions	Repudiates: “extremely weak to nonexistent” [6]
Carl A. P. Ruck (BU)	Mentor figure; 1978 hypothesis co-author	Stands by Eleusis hypothesis; “conflicted” about the project; rejects any religious revival; co-authored the 2026 feasibility study [6][15]
Andrew Koh (Yale)	Archaeochemistry champion	Incrementalist; warns against “light-year jumps” [41]
Charles Stang (Harvard CSWR)	Sympathetic host	“I expect we will find it...but I don’ t think we have found it” [5]
D.C.A. Hillman	Adviser	Felt his research was “hijacked” [6]
Jerry Brown / Chris Bennett	Entheogen-scholar reviewers	“Overreach,” “speculation as fact” [3][45]
Muraresku himself	Author	“Sexy circumstantial evidence,” no smoking gun [5]

7. The money and institutional layer (provenance data for Aletheia)

- **Athanatos Foundation** = Athanatos World Inc., EIN 47-5267002, Boulder — a re-purposed 501(c) (3) formerly “109 World” (yoga retreats); Muraresku President (\$105k FY2024). [50][51] Revenue: \$520k (FY2023), \$210k (FY2024); a **\$4.0M grant from Endaoment** (crypto donor-advised fund; ultimate donor anonymized) in tax period 2025-06. [51]
- **YAPP funding disclosure (peer-reviewed)**: “the Yale Ancient Pharmacology Program has been generously supported by E. Jhong, Robert and MeiLi Hefner Foundation, Athanatos Foundation, and B. Muraresku.” [52]
- **Athanatos portfolio** maps closely onto Graham Hancock’s subject matter (Younger Dryas/Comet Research Group, Robert Schoch, geopolymer pyramids, Amazon geoglyphs) plus Harvard/Berkeley psychedelics-grant convening; Hancock wrote TIK’s foreword. [42][53]
- **Implication for the pipeline**: the TIK-aimed research strand (EPOPTeia’s kykeon chemistry; YAPP’s Delphi/Iseion and Vatican proposals) is financed and partly staffed by the hypothesis’s stakeholders. This does not impeach the chemistry — it means naive source-counting overstates independent corroboration. Flag TIK-relevant evidence records with an “interested patronage” tag rather than excluding them.

8. Assessment (orchestrator verdict)

1. **TIK-C001/C002 (ancient ritual drug use generally): WELL SUPPORTED.** Post-2020 archaeochemistry has converted this from inference to direct chemistry across three continents. The Athanatos-supplied highlights are accurately described. [31][9][10]
2. **TIK-C004 (chemical feasibility of an ergot-derived kykeon): WELL SUPPORTED as of Feb 2026** — with the caveat that feasibility studies by interested parties invite, and should receive, independent replication. [15]

3. **TIK-C003 (the kykeon was psychedelic): WEAKLY SUPPORTED.** One genuine datum (Mas Castellar), one demonstrated mechanism, no evidence from Eleusis itself, a non-psychoactive named recipe, and silent sanctuary accounts. The hypothesis is *possible and now chemically plausible*; it is not the default position and may never be testable short of Eleusis sampling.
4. **TIK-C006/C007 (transmission; psychedelic Eucharist): UNSUPPORTED to CONTRADICTED.** No residue, text, or art; documented Jewish antecedents; the connecting framework (C008) is itself rejected by mainstream scholarship. Even the book’s own evidentiary witnesses repudiate this half. Any honest evidence atlas must show this ladder failing at the transmission rung — not at chemistry.
5. **The most likely durable legacy of TIK** is institutional, not historical: it catalyzed funding (Athanatos → YAPP), mainstreamed archaeochemistry, and provoked the 2026 experiment. In that sense the book functions like the Younger Dryas impact hypothesis did for impact proxies — likely wrong in its grand claim, net-positive for measurement science.

9. Research agenda — “The Price of Truth” (decisive tests, priced)

ID	Test	What it settles	Rough cost	Feasibility
TIK-R001	Petition Greek Central Archaeological Council for ORA (GC-MS/LC-HRMS) of curated Eleusis vessels (kernoi, libation cups) + Telesterion floor sediments; split samples, two independent labs, preregistered alkaloid panel incl. LSA/iso-LSA/ ergopeptides	Directly tests C003 at the only site that matters	\$150–400k + diplomacy	The single decisive experiment. Blocked by permission, not science; the 2026 paper explicitly calls for it ^[15]
TIK-R002	Independent replication of the lye-hydrolysis protocol by a lab with no entheogen-advocacy ties, with blinded ergot samples of known variable EA content (0.01–7.26 mg/g)	Whether C004 survives independence; dose-control realism	\$50–100k	High; fastest credibility lever for the pro side

Table 3 – continued

ID	Test	What it settles	Rough cost	Feasibility
TIK-R003	Human or primate pharmacology of the actual lye preparation (ethics-limited; alternatively receptor-binding + toxicology profiling of the full reaction mixture incl. residual ergometrine/ergometrinine)	Whether the mixture is psychoactive-and-safe, not just ergopeptide-free	\$100–300k (in vitro)	Medium; in vivo human work likely unethical with crude preparation
TIK-R004	Obtain and re-verify the primary Mas Castellar publication (Juan-Tresserras 2002); if possible, re-sample curated vessel residues and the dental-calculus individual with modern UHPLC-HRMS	Upgrades the one archaeological datum from medium to high confidence	\$10–30k (archive); \$50k+ (re-sampling)	High for archive work
TIK-R005	Systematic ORA survey of early-Christian liturgical vessels/catacomb <i>refrigeria</i> ceramics (Vatican collections, Pontifical Commission material) with published-negative commitment	Tests C006/C007 where it could actually be found; a well-documented null result is nearly as valuable as a hit	\$200–500k	Low (access); Vatican “Pope’ s Pharmacy” study is proposal-stage only as of 2026 ^[41]

Table 3 – continued

ID	Test	What it settles	Rough cost	Feasibility
TIK-R006	Philological audit: systematic search of the Greek documentary record (sanctuary accounts, medical papyri, Dioscoridean tradition) for ergot/lysergamide-relevant vocabulary	Converts the argument from silence into a quantified one	\$20–50k	High
TIK-R007	Pre-registered adversarial collaboration: EPOPTeia + a skeptics-nominated lab co-design the next Eleusis-adjacent sampling study	Neutralizes the COI objection structurally	marginal on top of R001/R002	High if both sides agree

10. Pointers for the Aletheia pipeline (what to watch when the AI drafts this case)

1. **Split the ladder at Eleusis vs. Christianity (Insight 1).** The public debate’s main failure mode — and the failure mode an LLM will inherit from its training corpus — is blending the two. Score them separately; the transmission claim (C006) is the weakest rung and carries the entire Christian half.
2. **Three claim strengths exist.** Publisher > podcast > author’s scholarly concession. Assess the strong form; log the concession (E112) as evidence. The 5-model check should include one run explicitly prompted with the concession, to test verdict stability.
3. **Provenance must encode interest-networks, not just venues.** EPOPTeia, WRERI, Athanatos, YAPP, and TIK form one interested cluster; Pinwheel/Menorca/Bes/Tel Arad are independent of it. Naive source-counting will conflate them (Insight 4).
4. **Feasibility proof is the press-corpus trap.** Within a week of the 2026 paper, headlines had converted “feasibility” into “study finds ancient Greeks used processed ergot” (GreekReporter; nunc.ch). ^[54]^[55] Train the extractor to preserve the authors’ own scope language (“the focus of the study was to demonstrate the feasibility”). ^[15]
5. **Watch the empty-cell symmetry (Insight 2).** Both sides argue from the same absence at Eleusis. The atlas should represent this as one shared datum with two interpretations, and point the research agenda at R001 — the rare case where the decisive test is administrative, not scientific.
6. **Don’t overweight chronology (Insight 6).** Popular critics attack the timeline, which is wrong-headed; the load-bearing objection is the Jewish matrix and the collapsed *religionsgeschichtliche*

framework (C008). That framework rung should be a first-class claim in the atlas — it is contradicted regardless of any future chemistry.

7. **Extraction targets for sources:** (a) Juan-Tresserras 2002 primary text (Spanish/Catalan; currently known only via secondary citations — highest-value missing primary source); (b) Burkert 1987 pp. ~108–109 exact wording; (c) the Eleusinian sanctuary account inscriptions Clinton cites (IG volumes); (d) full text of Nadeau *Academia Letters* 4213; (e) the 2026 paper’s supplementary alkaloid-yield tables for the R002 replication design.
 8. **Suggested verdict labels if ratified:** C001, C002, C004, C010 → *Well supported*; C003 → *Weakly supported*; C005 → *Unresolved*; C006, C009 → *Unsupported*; C007, C008 → *Contradicted*. Overall: **Mixed** with high research priority.
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Appendix — Case file metadata

- Research basis: five deep-research dimension briefs (lineage 1978–2008; the 2026 kykeon experiment; post-2020 archaeochemistry; Athanatos/Yale institutional layer; the Eucharist claim) + orchestrator gap-fill; ~150 independent searches across the set; primary texts consulted where accessible (PNAS/PMC full texts, *Scientific Reports* full texts, PubMed records, ProPublica 990 filings, Reason, Harvard CSWR transcripts).
 - Known gaps: primary Mas Castellar publication; exact Burkert wording; identity of the \$4M Endowment donor (DAF-anonymized by design); no post-publication peer-reviewed rebuttal of the 2026 chemistry found as of 2026-08.
 - Companion files (working set): `research/immortality_key_dim03.md`, `_dim04.md`, `_dim06.md`, `_dim07.md`, `_dim08.md`, `_cross_verification.md`, `_insight.md`.
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